

IDOLiSH7: How Character Attachment Drives Collection

Mujia Chen



IDOLiSH7 is a character-driven idol game combining narrative, rhythm gameplay, card collection, and character development. Its four major idol groups have very different identities, ranging from newly debuted idols to established stars, and senior performers. This variety gives players multiple types of characters to connect with. The main question I want to explore is:

How does IDOLiSH7 turn character attachment into collection and long-term engagement?

Why do players become attached to certain characters?

Players connect with characters for different reasons. Some are attracted by illustration or voice acting, while others care more about personality, backstory, or personal relatability. Because of this, a strong cast should not make every character appealing in the same way. Characters need clear differences in appearance, personality, motivation, and life experience. IDOLiSH7 does this particularly well. One character becomes an idol partly to follow the path of his older idol brother. Another hopes that becoming famous enough will help his missing sister see him someday. These motivations give players something deeper to connect with beyond appearance.

For long-term attachment, characterization is especially important. Visual design may attract attention first, but personality and story give players reasons to keep caring. **A character does not need to appeal to everyone.** They need to appeal strongly to a specific group of players.

How Does Character Writing Affect Willingness to Collect?

Once players become emotionally attached to a character, their cards gain value beyond statistics. A card can represent a new illustration, costume, voice line, or another opportunity to interact with a favorite character. IDOLiSH7 reinforces this through its home system. Players can display idols, change their outfits, and visit other players' spaces.



Torao Mido's Outfit Customization Menu



Home System

Collection therefore becomes a form of self-expression. Owning many cards of one character can communicate: This is my favorite character. Cards also have gameplay value because they can be upgraded and used during rhythm gameplay. This combines **emotional, visual, gameplay, and social value**, making cards feel more meaningful than simple numerical upgrades.

How Do Limited Events Create Anticipation?

Limited banners create urgency because players know that missing a card may mean waiting a long time for another opportunity. The decision changes from “Do I want this card?” to “Will I regret not getting it now?”

In IDOLiSH7, many banners run for around a week, creating a relatively short decision window. The system works especially well because players already care about the characters. Scarcity does not create attachment by itself; it increases the urgency surrounding something the player already values.

What Makes Repetitive Daily Systems Tolerable?

Outside the story, rhythm gameplay is one of the game's main repeatable activities. To reduce daily workload, IDOLiSH7 provides features such as spending more stamina for multiplied rewards and automatic song completion. Players can therefore decide how much attention they want to give the game each day. This is important because daily activities should keep players connected without making the game feel like homework. The rhythm gameplay also fits

naturally with the idol theme. Players repeatedly listen to songs performed by characters they already like, creating a simple reinforcing loop:

Like A Character → Play Their Songs → Earn Resources → Collect More Content of This Character → Strengthen Attachment

How Does Presentation Make Rewards Feel Valuable?

A card's value should continue after the moment it is obtained. In IDOLiSH7, players can display favorite cards on the main interface, while characters respond to UI interactions with random voice lines.



A card of Haruka Isumi on the main interface

These small details make normal menu navigation feel more like character interaction. Different elements contribute different forms of value:

- Illustration creates visual appeal.
- Voice strengthens personality.
- UI interaction keeps the character involved in everyday play.

A reward feels more valuable when players can repeatedly experience ownership..

Design Takeaway

What interests me most about IDOLiSH7 is how many systems support the same goal: making players care about particular characters.

- Story creates attachment.
- Cards turn attachment into collection.
- Music encourages repeated interaction.
- Customization supports self-expression.
- UI feedback keeps characters present in everyday play.

Together, they create a larger loop:

Discover → Understand → Attach → Collect → Display → Interact → Strengthen Attachment

The most important thing being designed is not only the story, but also the relationship between the player and the character. So design systems that give players more reasons to care about them after they are collected!